

settle the issue. Experts point out that, as a principle, for the Lok Sabha, GDP-weightage is deeply problematic. It is meant to be the House of the People that represents citizens, not tax-paying units or productive capacity. If GDP becomes a determinant of seats, richer states will enjoy greater parliamentary weight not because they have more people, but because they produce more output. Also, as BJP MP Tejashwi Surya pointed out during the debate in Parliament, GDP is more volatile. "Does that mean we would have to reduce or increase the representation of the state every year?" he asked.

No major democracy, be it the United States, the United Kingdom, Germany, Canada or Australia, allocates seats in the lower house by fiscal contribution. The closest international analogue that meets the South's concern is the American solution: the House has representatives by state population, but the Senate has two seats for every state. The Rajya Sabha, by design, does not currently play that role. Its allocation roughly tracks Lok Sabha strength, a fact the 131st Amendment would have distorted further by shifting the Lok Sabha-Rajya Sabha ratio from 2.2 to 3.3. The real answer, therefore, is not to convert the Lok Sabha into a partly GDP-weighted chamber but evolve a larger expansion formula for both Houses that addresses the key concerns raised during the debate.

"USING GDP AS A BASIS FOR DELIMITATION IS UNPRINCIPLED. IT SUBORDINATES POLITICAL EQUALITY TO ECONOMIC PERFORMANCE. IT PENALISES VOTERS FOR THE ECONOMIC FAILURES OF STATE GOVERNMENTS"

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Q. WHAT'S THE BEST WAY FORWARD?

BJP leaders in private conversations argue that the Opposition parties will have to be engaged more at the highest level as these changes will have to be eventually implemented and will require constitutional and legislative work. As one of them put it, "The purpose of the bill that collapsed was to prepone the discussions and implement both the reservation for women and the most complex delimitation process in independent India's history. It still has to be done, and we need the Opposition on board."

Experts say the fastest, fairest way out of this imbroglio is to stop pretending that all representation questions in India can be solved in one constitutional stroke. That is what doomed the 2026 attempt. It tried to deliver women's reservation, redefine the timing of delimitation, use a particular Census base, expand the House, and quieten southern fears in one package. It was too much, too soon, and too politically loaded.

A workable path would proceed in stages. First, political parties should reach a consensus on how the core reform of providing women reservation without dragging it through the quicksand of delimitation politics. Delimitation, in fact, should be negotiated separately, with safeguards to ensure that the Commission appointed is insulated from political influence. Also, that parliamentary reservation for OBCs, or even a sub-quota for OBC women within women's reservation, would require its own constitutional debate and data foundation. Trying to settle that issue in the middle of women's reservation implementation could cause the entire project to collapse again.

Meanwhile, Census 2027 should be completed as India cannot keep redesigning representation based on demographic assumptions through national sample surveys. Before the delimitation process begins, Parliament and the states need a clear and public framework: what Census will be used, how much the House will be expanded and why, whether existing regional shares will be broadly protected, and what safeguards will exist against gerrymandering. The terms of the exercise should be politically settled before the lines are drawn. The impasse must be broken at the earliest for Indian women to claim their rightful place in the edifice of parliamentary democracy. ■